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Air Force to Upgrade MQ-9’s Mission and Capabilities for Near-Peer Fight

April 21, 2021 | By John A. Tirpak

The Air Force is upgrading the [MQ-9 Reaper](#) fleet to give it new relevance against near-peers, make it more survivable, and extend its useful life another 10-15 years, the Air Force Life Cycle Management Center announced.

A delivery order contract covering 19 production aircraft to prime contractor General Atomics, worth \$272.3 million, was awarded April 21.

The Reaper fleet’s mission “is now shifting” from providing intelligence, surveillance, and reconnaissance/strike against Counter-Violent Extremist Organizations (C-VEOs) to missions in contested airspace, AFLCMC said.

The suite of new capabilities is “closely held,” but the first upgrade will be a self-protection anti-jam antenna system, the Air Force said. Other improvements will include Link 16, new weapons, “increased electric power,” and upgrades to the aircraft’s electro-optical and infrared systems. The



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“With these smart investments, the Air Force projects that MQ-9 will remain operationally viable through the end of the platform’s projected service life of 2035,” AFLCMC said in response to a query.

The service said it would not answer questions about an electronic warfare capability for the MQ-9 platform, despite the acknowledgment of an increased electrical power capability.

Air Combat Command “has directed us to add technology into the platform, which signals the MQ-9 can offer more capability than just C-VEO operations

over the next 10 to 15 years,” said Lt. Col. Nick Jordan, AFLCMC Material Leader for MQ-9 Production and Retrofit. “It can remain relevant with these added and upgraded technologies.”

The upgrades will “allow the platform to offer a host of new capabilities for combatant commanders and warfighters around the world,” AFLCMC said in a press release.

Air Force leaders have said in recent years that they need an enhanced, low-observable aircraft—[notionally, an “MQ-X”](#)—to fill the Reaper’s ISR/strike mission in contested airspace. AFLCMC said that while the MQ-9 is



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